

The Acer Ferrari had the best graphics solution in the form of a PCI-Express ATi Radeon X700. The Samsung X20 had an ATi Mobility Radeon X600, which was the second-best solution. The above two led the pack in the gaming benchmark scores. The other laptops had graphics solutions such as the ATi X300 and Intel integrated graphics.

The Acer Ferrari came with a slot-loading multi-format DVD burner. The Fujitsu and the LG, too, had multi-format DVD-Writers. The MSI laptops were equipped with DVD-RW drives. The IBM and Samsung laptops came with only combo drives. The Acer Ferrari had a port replicator, which can be used to add ports. It also had a DVI connector to connect an external digital display such as an LCD.

The IBM had a night lamp feature, which illuminates the keyboard so you can work at night with the lights off! Scroll scope on the touchpad was another noteworthy feature found on a few of the laptops—the LG, MSI and Samsung.

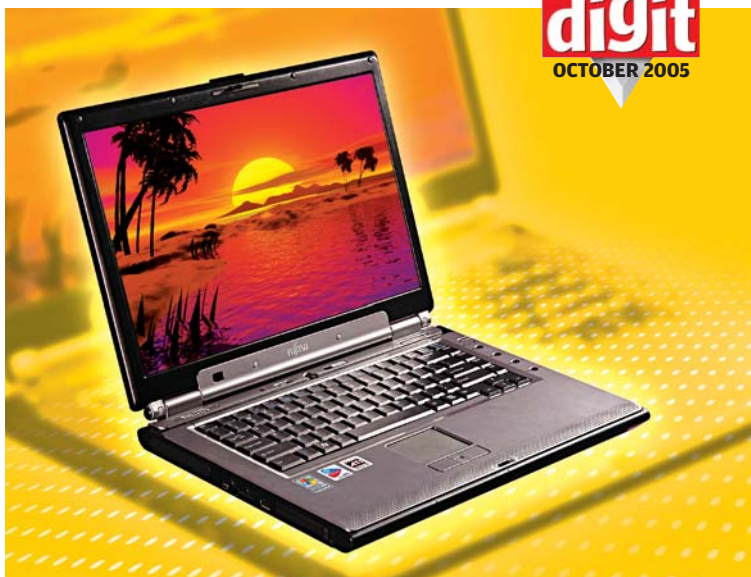
Usability

The IBM T43 had the smallest form factor, which was expected since it was the laptop with the smallest LCD.

But the Samsung X20 weighed less at 3 kg despite having a larger form factor. The Fujitsu LBN3510 was the heaviest at 3.85 kg.

Ergonomics

The Acer Ferrari scored the highest in terms of accessibility of ports, followed closely by the IBM: their ports were nicely spread around the periphery and were easily accessible. In the keyboard feel and touchpad sensitivity ratings, none could match the IBM T43, which goes to prove that the reputation IBM has for its excellent keyboards and touchpad is justified.



Fujitsu Lifebook LBN3510

The Acer Ferrari could only come a close second. Ergonomically too, the IBM was a real pleasure to work with. The Acer and Fujitsu tied for second place in the ergonomics department.

The speakers on the Acer Ferrari and the Fujitsu LBN3510 were the best. Samsung's X20 sounded OK and got the next-best rating.

Package contents

The Fujitsu LBN3510, LG LW60 Express and MSI Megabook M630 came with Windows XP Home Edition SP2 preinstalled, whereas the rest came with Windows XP Professional SP2 preinstalled. A driver and recovery CD or DVD of some sort accompanied each laptop.

All the laptops came with some sort of CD-

Samsung Note PC M40 Plus

The Samsung Note PC M40 Plus was the only laptop we received this time round that had a large 17-inch 16:10 wide-screen LCD display that supported a resolution of 1440 x 900.

This Intel Centrino Mobile technology-based laptop has an 1800 MHz Intel Pentium M processor with 512 MB of DDR RAM at 333 MHz. It has an 80 GB 5400 rpm hard drive. There's a DVD multi-format drive that can read and write all DVD formats, including DVD-RAM.

The M40 Plus has three USB ports, a FireWire port and a slot for a PCMCIA II card. Memory card support is limited to Memory Stick. 10/100 LAN as well as a 56 Kbps modem are featured. Sadly, this laptop lacks both infrared and Bluetooth.

The ATi Mobility Radeon 9700 with 64 MB of VRAM provides a decent gaming experience. In the game tests at 1024 x 768, the laptop logged 82.2 and 47.24 in <Call of Duty> and <FarCry> respectively. The speakers are decent as laptop speakers

go. There is a D-Sub connector as well as S-Video out - just in case you feel the urge to go beyond 17-inch.

In the Business Winstone 2004 benchmark, the M40 Plus scored 19.3, which means it'll run Office applications well. PowerPoint presentations will run fast, and so will MS Access. The PCMark 04 score of 3504 can also be termed above average.

Build quality is just about average, but the silver-aluminium look brings out the lifestyle value of this laptop. And despite the large display and form factor, the M40 Plus is surprisingly lightweight at 2.99 kg.

Ergonomically, the laptop is comfortable to work with, though the touchpad and keyboard are not the best of the lot. It aced the DisplayMate test, which returns the overall quality of the display.

Samsung has provided an innovative, large four-way button that is used in conjunction with the keys for hotkey access. This feature is fun to work with.

The M40 Plus comes with Windows XP Professional SP2 pre-installed. The other bundled software are PowerDVD, Nero and Ulead.

Rs 1,29,990 is a bit high for the M40 Plus considering the lack of several features which, we think, could have easily been accommodated.

